downstream process breaks down. Our only hope for truth to matter is for truth to be recorded and widely disseminated.

In the modern world, few actors in the economy have an incentive to do a good job of measurement. As an example, academic economists are quite comfortable doing research with faulty data, because the academic economists who will review their work do not ask questions about data quality.

Stage 2 of the policy pipeline is descriptive and causal research. This requires a research community which will study the data, establish broad facts and regularities, and explore causal connections.

This work should be primarily grounded in the Indian locale. Academic researchers are too often swayed by the curiosity of journal editors and referees in a different continent. This hampers the choice of questions to pursue and the quality of research design through which those questions are sought to be answered.

Stage 3 of the policy pipeline is the creative phase of inventing and proposing new policy solutions. A large menu of choices needs to be at hand, for possible policy pathways. The republic is always short-changed when ‘there is no alternative’ (TINA) to one mainstream idea.

At present in India, there is no community which systematically looks for fully articulated solutions. Academic journals do not publish policy proposals, hence academic researchers are not keen to invent policy proposals.

Stage 4 of the policy pipeline is the public debate where rival solutions compete with each other. This requires a vigorous process of debate and discussion, in writing and in seminars. A broad consensus needs to come about on what will work, within the analytical community.

In the Indian context, this is often assisted by the expert committee process. The purpose of the expert committee process is to sift through an array of possible policy pathways that are in the fray at the end of stage 3, and filter down to a few which make sense. The best expert committee reports help mainstream novel ideas in policy reform, and pull together the state of the art into a report. As Isher Ahluwalia says, nothing gets done by